Nature & childhood

Freedom can be damaged

1 The Schoolboy: meaning

Blake's child enjoys nature but suffers under fearful schooling. Bird-in-cage and damaged-plant images link restriction to lost development.

Cruel eye: authority becomes surveillance. Appeals to parents make adults responsible for the future.

2 Blake: how it works

Six five-line stanzas; songlike pattern contrasts with confinement. Questions demand an answer rather than accepting adult power.

Context: childhood and resistance to restrictive authority. Compare Catrin's mother–child conflict.

Pleasure can return

3 Wordsworth: meaning

A solitary walker finds company in dancing daffodils. Later, the **inward eye** brings the scene back.

Personification moves the flowers' dance into the heart. The gain is emotional wealth.

4 Wordsworth: how it works

Four six-line stanzas, ABABCC. Final stanza shifts from past encounter to recurring present pleasure.

Romantic nature, imagination and personal feeling. Solitude becomes rewarding, unlike the opening loneliness.

Pleasure can decay

5 Blackberry Picking: meaning

Wordsworth — Pleasure returns →

Heaney — Fruit decays →

Heaney's remembered childhood moves from eager collecting to rotten fruit. Sensory attraction becomes disgust.

Blood, eyes and Bluebeard imagery add unease. Desire outlasts knowledge of inevitable decay.

6 Heaney: how it works

Long first stanza gathers excitement; shorter second stanza reverses it. Rural Northern Irish childhood informs concrete details.

Compare: Wordsworth preserves pleasure through memory; Heaney cannot preserve fruit. Blake blames restriction, not natural decay.